

teacher and civil rights campaigner, Octavius Catto. He was shot on election day by a Democratic Party worker and died as a result of the wounds. The onset of economic depression further hardened Northern attitudes. Although the depression's causes were complex and international, in the United States the root was a frenzy of government-sponsored railroad development following the Civil War. Massive investment in unneeded railroad schemes created a speculative bubble that burst in 1873 as railroad stocks lost value. This led to widespread bank and business failure—notably the collapse of Jay Cooke & Co., the very bank that had raised hundreds of millions of dollars for the Union war effort by masterminding the selling of government bonds. This financial turmoil led to unemployment and wage cuts. Prosperity would not return until the 1880s.

Northerners suffering their own economic misfortunes were less likely to sympathize with the plight of Black people and the costs associated with Reconstruction programs. The Democratic Party capitalized on voter frustration and won enough seats in the 1874 election to gain control of the House of Representatives. From now on, Reconstruction would require accommodation to Democratic wishes.

In 1870, James Webster Smith from South Carolina became West Point's first Black cadet. He was severely harassed by fellow cadets, including President Grant's son, Fred.